LARISE BENGAL

Hindu votes through the politics of temples and festivals

TMC

- **TMC leaders are organising and participating in Ramnavami and Hanuman Jayanti rallies**
- **TMC-run municipalities in Nabadweep and Purulia urge closure of meat shops during Holi, Ramnavami**
- **Answering BJP's charges of being 'anti-Hindu', TMC chief Mamata Banerjee has repeatedly asserted her Hindu Brahmin identity**
- **Mamata Banerjee to inaugurate replica of Puri's Jagannath temple in Digha on April 30**
- **Kolkata's Kalighat temple to be renovated; a skywalk connecting it inaugurated**
- **Ganga aarti taking place along Hooghly, modelled after the one in Varanasi**



IN THE NAME OF RAM
Trinamool members take out a Ramnavami rally in Howrah, April 6

A COMMUNAL CAULDRON

West Bengal Chief Minister and TMC chief Mamata Banerjee has long been walking a political tightrope. While she prominently celebrates festivals like Durga Puja and Chhath Puja, she is equally visible championing welfare schemes for Muslims, attending Eid gatherings, and even appearing in a hijab. It's a carefully calibrated balancing act—aimed at projecting a Hindu-friendly image without alienating the crucial minority vote.

But though she is reassuring Muslims that all is well, the party's own politicians are going off-script as politics veers toward religious majoritarianism. In March, Suvendu Adhikari declared in the assembly that he would "drag minority MLAs of the TMC on to the streets" if the BJP came to power in 2026. In response, the TMC's Humayun Kabir threatened to break Adhikari's hands if he did not apologise. "My party comes second," he said. "My community comes first." Mamata also joined the fray, asserting her Hindu identity in the house, and accusing the BJP of "importing fake Hinduism to the state". It was a preview of the ideological battle shaping up ahead of the 2026 assembly election. Among the Muslim leaders who have been accused of making incendiary statements is Mamata's cabinet colleague and Jamiat Ulema-i-Hind leader Siddiqullah Chowdhury, who threatened to bring Kolkata to a standstill in protest over the Waqf law. "This isn't politics of slogans anymore," political analyst Nirmalya Mukherjee says. "It's a high-stakes cultural war. If leaders don't tread carefully, Bengal could be staring at a bloodbath."

Signs of the dangers of communal politics showed up just a day before the Murshidabad flare-up. On April 10, a video showing Muslims protesting the Waqf Act in a rally in Kolkata purportedly asking a bus driver to remove a saffron flag, went viral. Instantly accusing the TMC of appeasement, the BJP urged Hindus to display saffron flags at their homes on Hanuman Jayanti on April 12.

Adding fuel to this already volatile situation are influential religious bodies. Recently, Pirzada Toha Siddiqui, a prominent cleric of the Hooghly-based Furfura Sharif, called for a mosque to be constructed in Digha to "balance" the temple project. His more politically active kin, Abbas and Nawshad Siddiqui—founders of the Indian Secular Front (ISF)—are set to challenge the TMC's monopoly over Muslim votes.

The RSS, too, has expanded its grassroots reach in Bengal. It is clear that unlike during the 2021 assembly polls and the 2024 Lok Sabha elections in Bengal, where the BJP won 77 (out of 294) and 12 seats (out of 42) respectively, the state unit's abysmal organisational strength will have RSS backing. Analysts say that the BJP, emboldened by its 38.73 per cent vote share in 2024, is aiming for a 7-8 per cent swing in 2026. The increased turnout of Hindu voters, bolstered by RSS and VHP mobilisation, is key to its realisation.

The cacophony of religious politics drowns the everyday concerns of the common man. There is little to address with the crisis of unemployment or the endemic corruption as evident in multiple alleged scams. The only non-religious issues to have pierced the political din are the alleged irregularities in the RG Kar rape case and the recent Supreme Court cancellation of nearly 26,000 school jobs due to widespread manipulation in the recruitment process under the West Bengal School Service Commission. Yet temples, identity and imagined historical grievances dominate the political narrative. The fire in Murshidabad was not lit in a day. Bengal's political class has sedulously stoked it over the years. ■